Valiant Hearts: Play and Learn

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It is well known that video games are a very popular and innovative type of entertainment, but in education, they are not always viewed favorably, as they are often seen as a distraction to students. Considering video games as detrimental to education is not entirely appropriate and it is possible to demonstrate that, with the right approach, they can be used as a powerful learning tool. One of these games could be Valiant Hearts: The Great War, which presents World War I in an interactive way. The game takes us through important events of the war, and from the beginning, we can see that it presents the dates, places, and events that caused the conflict and each of its battles. This is something important to highlight as a way to aid learning since it strives to explain what is happening and why, adding all the necessary details to contextualize the event in space and time. Another strength of the game is that it is composed by rhythm, puzzle, and stealth sections, allowing it to feel like a dynamic experience in which the varied scenarios, characters, music, and mechanics serve to appeal to younger players or those with different learning methods. Also, optional collectibles provide additional details about the war and can spark interest in searching and self-learning by looking for them. The game is not very difficult and gives enough hints for players of different abilities to complete it, but still encourages concentration and problem-solving skills as an important part of the gameplay (skills that are important for learning as well). Some things that could be a drawback considering its context are, the appropriateness to all types of audiences, and the way it portrays war. Here the game does a great job taking advantage of its cartoon aesthetics and story, distancing itself from other video games set in the same context. It shows the reality of war but avoids graphic situations and glorification of violence as something fun, remembering that the struggle of both sides was not lived by virtual characters, but by real people. There are no super soldiers, the characters in the story are relatable, they feel, and their lives have been affected by war. In addition, it is clear that the game alone cannot fully teach a subject as extensive and important as the Great War, because despite its educational potential, the purpose of video games is still to provide entertainment. Even considering its limitations, the game can still be valuable for education because it does not dehumanize or show a one-sided view of the conflict while introducing the events of the war accurately and differently. With the accompaniment and guidance of teachers, games like this one can represent a way to introduce or complement the topics they teach rather than a distraction. Adding at the same time a new type of educational material that supports books, documentaries, or traditional classes, to attract and interest all types of students.